CONNECT WEEKLY

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A weekly review of national and South Yorkshire developments in education policy, inclusion, SEND, behaviour and accountability — weighted to primary and evidence sources, with links and a clear "so what for your school" line on the items that matter.

Useful? Forward it to a colleague. To join the circulation or partner with the network, get in touch.

TOP LINE

- Education Secretary Lucy Powell gave her first appearance before the Commons Education Select Committee on 4 November, and the standout line was her admission that the consequences schools face after Ofsted inspections 'need to change' — she argued that, for schools with large numbers of pupils with SEND, 'context is a penalty'. She also confirmed that devolving 16-19 funding to mayoral authorities will happen gradually rather than in one go, and that technical assessment should stay with human markers rather than AI.

  → **For your school:** *Nothing to action yet — this is ministerial intent, not a policy change — but worth flagging to your SLT and Ofsted lead as an early signal that inspection consequences for high-SEND-cohort schools may shift.*

- At the same hearing, Powell confirmed that the long-delayed legislation to reform the SEND system won't be published until early next year — the latest in a run of slippages that has now outlasted two education secretaries. It sits alongside the exclusion reform call for evidence flagged in last week's edition, due to close 19 November, as the two live strands of inclusion policy currently in motion.

  → **For your school:** *Keep expectations realistic in any sector messaging about SEND reform timing, and use the window before 19 November to get a view in on the exclusion reform proposals while that's still open.*

- The DfE marked the start of Care Leavers Month with a new Care Leaver Homelessness Reduction Action Plan, aiming to halve the number of care-experienced people who become homeless and giving councils new duties and local targets to prevent it. It builds on the wider £3.5bn National Plan to End Homelessness announced last December, with care leavers identified as a priority group.

  → **For your school:** *Worth sharing with whoever leads on post-16 transition and care-experienced pupil support, particularly for any Year 13s approaching 18 this year.*

- A genuinely lighter week elsewhere: nothing new and reliably dated surfaced on funding, behaviour/attendance data or Ofsted's framework specifically beyond the committee hearing above, and Sheffield's own news was dominated by schools returning from half term on Monday. DfE's autumn 2025/26 suspensions and exclusions statistics are still awaited, with no exact publication day yet confirmed.

  → **For your school:** *No action needed this week — a reasonable one to catch up on the two live inclusion-policy strands above instead.*

DATES FOR THE DIARY

11 Nov 2026 — 5pm deadline for Care to Learn and 16-19 Bursary Fund claim forms, per the DfE's November Update.

19 Nov 2026 — DfE's call for evidence on exclusion reform (internal suspension, reintegration partnerships, day-one schoolwork) closes.

Nov 2026 (exact day tbc) — DfE due to publish autumn 2025/26 suspensions and permanent exclusions statistics for England.

15 Dec 2026 — NEU's formal strike ballot of teachers and support staff over pay, funding and workload closes.

NATIONAL POLICY

- **Lucy Powell's first Education Select Committee hearing sets the tone for her tenure.** In her first appearance before the Commons Education Select Committee since taking over from Bridget Phillipson in July's reshuffle, Powell ranged across Ofsted, SEND, 16-19 funding and AI in assessment — telling MPs that devolving post-16 funding to mayoral combined authorities, including South Yorkshire's, will happen gradually rather than in one go, and that technical qualifications should keep human markers rather than AI because of the risk it could 'worsen prejudice'. Taken together with her Ofsted comments below, it reads as a secretary of state still finding her feet on substance while signalling she wants change on process. (FE Week)

  → **For your school:** *Worth a skim if your trust has a view on how 16-19 funding devolution should work locally — South Yorkshire MCA already holds the adult education budget, so this is a live local question, not just a Westminster one.*

OFSTED & ACCOUNTABILITY

- **Powell says inspection consequences 'need to change' — and names SEND as the reason.** Pressed by MPs, Powell said the consequences schools face after an Ofsted inspection need to change, arguing that for schools with high numbers of pupils with SEND, 'context is a penalty' — an acknowledgment that current accountability measures can punish schools for the cohort they serve rather than the quality of what they do. She also admitted Ofsted has 'a lot of work to do' to recruit enough inspectors with multi-academy trust experience, a gap trust leaders have flagged repeatedly since the report-card framework launched a year ago. Neither comment commits to a specific change, but both suggest the next phase of Ofsted reform may focus on consequences and inspector expertise rather than the framework itself. (Tes)

  → **For your school:** *If your school's SEND cohort has shaped recent inspection outcomes, this is worth raising with your MAT or diocese now, while the department is openly weighing changes to consequences rather than framework detail.*

INCLUSION, SEND & BEHAVIOUR

- **SEND reform legislation slips again, to early next year.** At the same committee hearing, Powell confirmed that legislation to reform the SEND system — originally expected this autumn — won't come until early next year, telling MPs 'we are taking the time this needs'. It's the latest in a series of delays to SEND reform spanning two education secretaries and over a year, against a backdrop — covered in last week's edition — of council SEND deficits the OBR expects to keep widening. The live, open strand of inclusion policy right now is the narrower exclusion reform call for evidence, covering internal suspension, reintegration partnerships and day-one schoolwork, which closes 19 November. (Nursery World)

  → **For your school:** *Treat full SEND system reform as a 2027 conversation for planning purposes, but don't let that delay distract from responding to the exclusion reform call for evidence, which is still open and more likely to move quickly.*

FUNDING

- **Quiet week on funding specifically, after last week's Budget coverage.** Nothing new and reliably dated on schools funding surfaced this week beyond routine DfE administration — the department's 4 November update to local authorities and FE providers was largely a reminder of existing deadlines (see diary) rather than new money or policy. That's consistent with the Budget having already set the tone for this cycle, as covered last week; the next genuine funding moment is likely to be the DfE's own breakdown of the settlement, still awaited. (GOV.UK)

  → **For your school:** *No action needed this week — keep the Care to Learn/16-19 Bursary Fund deadline (11 November) on your radar if your setting has eligible students.*

SAFEGUARDING & WELLBEING

- **New Care Leaver Homelessness Reduction Action Plan marks the start of Care Leavers Month.** The DfE has published a Care Leaver Homelessness Reduction Action Plan, setting new council duties and local targets aimed at halving the number of care-experienced people who become homeless. It sits under the wider £3.5bn National Plan to End Homelessness announced last December, with care leavers specifically named as a priority group given how disproportionately likely they are to experience homelessness after leaving care. For secondary schools, the direct relevance is mainly to Year 13 and any post-16 provision supporting care-experienced young people as they approach 18. (GOV.UK)

  → **For your school:** *Worth passing to your designated teacher for looked-after children or post-16/transition lead, particularly for any care-experienced students turning 18 this academic year.*

SHEFFIELD & SOUTH YORKSHIRE

- **A quiet week locally, dominated by the return from half term.** Sheffield's schools returned from the autumn half term on Monday 2 November, which kept the city's own education news light this week. The one genuinely new local story was a planning application, reported Thursday, to convert a former 1860s church into a small independent school with five classrooms for around 30 pupils — a reminder of the steady trickle of small independent and alternative-provision openings in the city, distinct from the mainstream place-planning and SEND funding stories covered in recent editions. (The Star)

  → **For your school:** *No action needed, but worth noting if your trust tracks new AP or independent provision opening near your catchment.*

JARGON-BUSTER – ABIE

Comes up wherever DfE talks about this year's attendance drive.

Short for Attendance Baseline Improvement Expectation — the individual minimum attendance improvement target DfE now sets for every school, introduced alongside the national attendance roadmap published in November 2025. It's the mechanism behind the push towards the Children's Commissioner's 100% attendance goal, and the benchmark your own attendance data is quietly being measured against this year.

MAPS IN PRACTICE – TOOL SPOTLIGHT: SCHOOL+

A strong inclusion strategy is only as good as the cohort picture beneath it.

School+ is the MAPs cohort-vulnerability framework — it maps who your at-risk pupils are and why, giving your inclusion strategy an evidence base rather than a wish list. Explore School+

SOURCES MONITORED

Weighted official- and evidence-first. X is monitored for early signals from official accounts and named commentators, and corroborated against a primary source before anything is included.

Source	Type	What we track
OFFICIAL & STATUTORY		
DfE / GOV.UK	Government	Policy, funding, statutory guidance and statistics
Ofsted	Government	Inspection framework, report cards, annual report
Explore Education Statistics	Government data	Exclusions, suspensions, attendance, census data
House of Commons Library	Parliament	Neutral briefings on bills and policy
RESEARCH & EVIDENCE		
Education Endowment Foundation	Research	Evidence-based guidance, incl. inclusive teaching
NFER	Research	Assessment, workforce, disadvantage
Education Policy Institute	Think tank	Policy analysis and the disadvantage gap
Institute for Fiscal Studies	Think tank	School funding and spending analysis
FFT Education Datalab	Data analysis	Data-driven analysis of attainment and exclusions
INCLUSION & PREVENTION SPECIALISTS		

Source	Type	What we track
The Difference	Charity	Whole-school inclusion; “Who’s Losing Learning?”
IPPR	Think tank	Lost learning, exclusions, SEND reform
Youth Endowment Fund	Research	What works to prevent youth violence & exclusion
Centre for Social Justice	Think tank	Exclusion tracker and social-mobility policy
Whole School SEND	Network	SEND practice, resources and reviews
SECTOR PRESS & COMMENTARY		
Schools Week	Press	Breaking sector news and investigations
Tes	Press	Practice, policy and workforce
The Guardian (Education)	Press	National coverage and comment
X (monitored)	Social	DfE, Ofsted, EEF and named voices — corroborated before use
LOCAL & REGIONAL		
The Star (Sheffield)	Local press	Local schools and Ofsted outcomes
Sheffield City Council	Local government	Council decisions, funding and local strategy
South Yorkshire MCA & Careers Hub	Regional	Regional skills, careers and funding

Connect Weekly is part of Sheffield Connect. Compiled by Andy Marsden, Sector Inclusion Lead.

For circulation across the network and partners. Figures reflect the latest published data at the date of this brief.